



World Mental Health Day

World Mental Health Day falls on Saturday 10 October in 2026, so the assembly here is written for the Friday before and it ends by telling students what is happening the following week. You choose one of two ways to run that week: five themed lunchtimes, one for each of the Five Ways to Wellbeing, or a single wall that fills up with anonymous cards. There is a PSHE lesson as well, on what to say when a friend tells you they are struggling, which is a conversation most students have never been taught how to have.

Before you start. A week on mental health brings things to the surface, and some of it will come to you. Tell your safeguarding lead before the assembly, and make sure anybody running a lunchtime or reading the wall knows who to pass a disclosure on to. Slide 10 of the assembly asks for a named member of staff and a reporting route, so fill those in before you show it.

Pick one of these first

Option	What it takes	Where it is
Five themed lunchtimes	A member of staff at each of five lunchtimes, and a bit of shopping. It gets far more students involved, and it asks the most of you.	Pages 2 to 4
One Wall of Words	A wall, one photocopy, and five minutes at the end of each day. Start here if your school has not marked this day before.	Pages 5 and 6

What you do, and when

When	What you do	What to print
Three weeks before	Decide which option you are running, book the assembly, and ask for whatever room or wall space it needs.	Nothing yet
The week before	Fill in every square bracket in the assembly slides. Do all the printing in one go, and the shopping if you picked the lunchtimes.	Page 4 or 6, and pages 8 to 10
Friday 9 October	Run the assembly. Show slides 6 and 7 for the lunchtimes or 8 and 9 for the wall, and hide the pair you are not using.	Nothing
Monday to Friday	Your option runs every day. Page 3 (lunchtimes) or page 5 (the wall) says what to watch for.	Nothing
Any point that week	Run the PSHE lesson, in a tutor slot or a PSHE hour. It works on its own if the rest of the week falls through.	Already done

Worth knowing

- The tenth of October is the date every year and it moves around the week. In a year when it lands on a weekday, run the assembly that morning and start the week the Monday after, and change the line on slide 4 that says it falls on a Saturday. The theme changes every year too, so look the new one up first.

None of this is complicated. The hardest part is finding five members of staff who can give up a lunchtime, and that is why the wall is here as the other option.





The five days

One activity at lunchtime, every day of the week. Each one takes a different one of the Five Ways to Wellbeing, the framework the New Economics Foundation set out in 2008 that the NHS still uses. None of the days depends on the one before, so the week still works if one of them falls through.

What happens, day by day

Day	What happens	What you need	Who runs it
Monday Connect	Tea and Talk. Tea, squash and biscuits on a table, with conversation cards laid out, and students sit and talk to somebody.	Urn or kettle, squash, biscuits, cups. The conversation cards from Wellbeing Check-Ins work well here.	One member of staff and four students
Tuesday Be active	Laps at Lunch. Students walk a lap of the field or the yard, and somebody keeps a tally on a board. The whole school total is announced on Friday.	A whiteboard or flip chart and a marker. Nothing else.	One member of staff on the tally
Wednesday Take notice	The Quiet Room. One room open, no talking required. Colouring sheets, a jigsaw, board games.	A room, a few jigsaws or board games, and colouring sheets and pencils.	One member of staff, sitting quietly
Thursday Keep learning	Ask Me Anything. The answers to the questions in the box go up on a board at lunchtime, and staff stand next to it.	The question box from Monday, large paper, and two members of staff who have written the answers the night before.	Two members of staff
Friday Give	Green Ribbons. Green is the day's colour. Students take a ribbon, write something good about somebody on a tag, and tie it to a fence or a railing.	Green ribbon, scissors, and luggage tags or card cut into tags.	One member of staff and four students

The shopping

What	How much	Roughly
Squash, teabags and biscuits	Enough for forty or fifty students	A supermarket own brand shop
Paper cups	A pack of fifty	Under five pounds
Green ribbon	One roll, about twenty metres	A few pounds
Luggage tags, or card to cut up	Around a hundred	A few pounds, or free from the reprographics offcuts
Prices and brands date, and they are different everywhere. Treat these as a rough steer and check them against your own shop. Most of this can be cut back: squash on its own is enough for Monday, and reprographics offcuts will do for Friday's tags.		





The things that go wrong

Page 2 says what happens on each day. This page is the things that stop a day working if nobody has thought about them first.

MONDAY Tea and Talk

- Somebody has to be on the urn the whole time, and it cannot be the same person who is trying to talk to students.
- Put the question box out on this day, not on Thursday. It needs three days of questions in it before anybody can answer any of them.
- Check the allergy register before you buy biscuits, and keep an empty packet so a form tutor can check it.

TUESDAY Laps at Lunch

- Tell whoever is on duty outside first. A line of students walking laps of the field looks like something has happened if nobody has been told.
- A tally that nobody can see does not get anybody walking. Put the board where the queue for lunch can read it.
- School shoes on a wet field is what stops this working, so use the yard if it has rained.

WEDNESDAY The Quiet Room

- This is the day for the students who will not go near a stall, so do not put it in the hall. A small room is better than a big one.
- Say on the door that nobody has to talk. Students who think they will be asked why they came will not come.
- One member of staff, sitting down and not circulating. Somebody moving round the room checking on people changes what the room is for.

THURSDAY Ask Me Anything

- The answers have to be written the night before. Standing in front of a board answering questions about mental health off the top of your head is not fair on the member of staff or the student who asked.
- Read every question first and take out anything that names a student. If a question is really about one person, answer it in general terms.
- If a question is about somebody being in real trouble, that is a disclosure and it goes to your safeguarding lead rather than on the board.

FRIDAY Green Ribbons

- Cut the ribbon into lengths beforehand. Forty students and one pair of scissors is the whole lunchtime gone.
- Ask the site team where ribbons can be tied and whether they can stay up over the weekend.
- When you tell students not to sign the tags, tell them that staff read them before they go up.





Signs for the door

Cut along the lines. Five go on the door of whichever room you are using, one a day, and the last one goes on the question box. Write the room and the time on before you put it up.

MONDAY · CONNECT

Tea and Talk

Tea, squash and a biscuit, and somebody to sit with. Room Time

TUESDAY · BE ACTIVE

Laps at Lunch

One lap, or ten. Every one goes on the board. Meet at Time

WEDNESDAY · TAKE NOTICE

The Quiet Room

Open to anybody. You do not have to talk. Room Time

THURSDAY · KEEP LEARNING

Ask Me Anything

The answers to your questions are up on the board. Room Time

FRIDAY · GIVE

Green Ribbons

Take a ribbon, write a tag, tie it up. Where Time

ALL WEEK · ASK ME ANYTHING

The Question Box

Put your question in here. Do not put your name on it. The answers go up on Thursday.





One wall, all week

A blank wall fills up over five days with anonymous cards. On each one a student writes the thing they would want somebody to say to them on a bad day. It needs a wall, a photocopy and five minutes at the end of each day, so it is the option to pick if nobody can staff five lunchtimes.

How it runs

When	What happens
The Friday before	The assembly launches it. Slides 8 and 9 tell students where the wall is and what to write. Fill in the place before you show them.
Monday morning	Put the wall up: backing paper, a heading, a stack of cards from page 6 and a pot of pens. Somewhere busy and reasonably public is better than a quiet corridor.
Every day	Students write a card at break or lunch and pin it up. Nobody signs anything.
End of every day	A member of staff reads everything that went up. Take down anything unkind, anything that names a student, and anything that reads as somebody asking for help, and pass the last of those to your safeguarding lead.
Friday	The wall should be covered. Read three or four of the best out in assembly or in form time.
After	Leave it up. Taking it down on the Friday afternoon undoes most of what it was for.
Anonymous means the writer is not named, not that nobody reads it. Say that out loud in the assembly and put it on the wall itself. A wall nobody checks will eventually carry something you would not want a student to find, and if somebody writes a card because they are worried, it only helps if an adult sees it.	

The heading

Write THE WALL OF WORDS along the top on a strip of sugar paper, or print slide 8 of the assembly deck and put that up instead. Underneath it, in smaller letters: write the thing you would want somebody to say to you on a bad day. Staff read what goes up.

If you are running both options, the wall goes up on the Monday morning and the five lunchtimes run alongside it. It gives the students who would never come to a lunchtime something they can still join in with.





Cards for the wall

Six to a sheet. Print as many as you have students and leave a stack beside the wall with a pot of pens.

WHAT I WOULD WANT SOMEBODY TO SAY TO ME <i>Do not sign it. Staff read what goes up.</i>	WHAT I WOULD WANT SOMEBODY TO SAY TO ME <i>Do not sign it. Staff read what goes up.</i>
WHAT I WOULD WANT SOMEBODY TO SAY TO ME <i>Do not sign it. Staff read what goes up.</i>	WHAT I WOULD WANT SOMEBODY TO SAY TO ME <i>Do not sign it. Staff read what goes up.</i>
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When a Friend Tells You They Are Struggling

Students sort eight real replies into piles, learn four things that help, pick apart two versions of the same conversation, and then spend the middle of the lesson on their feet rewriting eight things people really said. Nobody is asked about their own week, and nothing they write is handed in.

Before you start. Tell your safeguarding lead the lesson is running. A lesson about what to say when somebody is struggling usually means one or two students come and talk to you afterwards. Slide 10 has a space for a named member of staff, so fill that in first. The exit slip on slide 17 is private, is not collected and is not read out, and the slide says so.

The hour

Time	What happens	Slides
5 min	Sort the eight response cards into helped, did not help, and it depends. They have to agree as a table, and the arguing is the useful part.	3
5 min	Take the three piles back. The middle pile is where the lesson starts.	4
8 min	The four moves: notice, ask twice, listen, stay. One slide each, with what gets a real answer and what does not.	5 to 10
6 min	Read the two conversations. Find the line where Sam stops telling the truth, then read the second one and say what Jay did differently.	11 and 12
5 min	One together, out loud. Read a first line, pairs agree the next one, take four answers.	13
12 min	The Rewrite. Pairs go to four of the eight station cards and leave a better version on a strip at each.	14
7 min	Back to the first station. Mark the strips against the three things on slide 15, then read the best one out.	15
8 min	Argue about being asked not to tell anyone, which has no clean answer, then the exit slip: two names, folded and taken away.	16 and 17

Worth knowing

- The Rewrite is what makes this a doing lesson rather than a talking one, so protect the twelve minutes. Spreading the eight stations round the room stops pairs bunching up at one card, and a pair who finish early should read the strips already there rather than start a fifth.
- Move four gets left out more than any of the others, and it is the one doing the safeguarding work: do not promise to keep it secret, tell one adult, and tell your friend you are telling them. Sam and Jay in the two conversations are both deliberately ungendered, so change either name if it matches a student in the class.

This lesson does not teach students to spot a mental health problem, and it should not try to. It teaches them what to say to a friend, which is the situation they will actually find themselves in.





Eight things people say

One set per table, cut up. Somebody has just told a friend that they are struggling, and these are the replies. Students sort them into helped, did not help, and it depends.

“You’ll be fine. Everyone gets like that.” 1	“That sounds exhausting. How long has it been like this?” 2
“Have you tried going for a run? That sorted me right out.” 3	“I’m not going anywhere.” 4
“Same though. I get like that too.” 5	“You should tell someone.” 6
“Are you okay?” 7	“Do you want to talk about it, or do you just want company?” 8

For you, not the table. Nearly every class puts two, four and eight in the helped pile, and one and three in the other. Five, six and seven end up in the middle, and slide 4 picks those three apart.





Eight station cards

Cut these up and put one on each wall space around the room, with a pile of rewrite strips underneath. Every one of them is something somebody really said when a friend opened up, and none of them was meant unkindly.

“You’ll be fine.”

Which of the four moves does this one miss?

“At least you’ve still got your mates.”

Which of the four moves does this one miss?

“Have you tried just not thinking about it?”

Which of the four moves does this one miss?

“That happened to my cousin, and she...”

Which of the four moves does this one miss?

“You’re always saying that.”

Which of the four moves does this one miss?

“You should really talk to someone about that.”

Which of the four moves does this one miss?

“Are you okay?”

Which of the four moves does this one miss?

“Cheer up. It might never happen.”

Which of the four moves does this one miss?





Rewrite strips

Four to a sheet. Cut into strips and leave a pile under each station card. One strip per pair per card, and initials go on the back. The three boxes at the foot are for the marking at the end, not for the pair who wrote it.

A BETTER VERSION OF WHAT THE CARD SAYS

Marking: tick each one this does.

Says what you noticed	Does not fix it	Leaves the door open
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